The Night Gardeners

A bedtime story for ages 4–8 · about 4 minutes to read aloud

When everyone in the town is asleep, the night gardeners come out.

They are very small, about the size of a teacup, and they are very fluffy, like dandelion puffs with tiny feet. They live in the grove at the edge of the woods, and they only work by moonlight.

Tonight, the oldest gardener, Thistle, rang a little bell made from an acorn cap. "Time to tend the grove," she said.

Bramble watered the moonflowers, which only open at night. One by one, they unfolded their silver petals and glowed.

Clover tucked the baby mushrooms in under blankets of moss, because the night was chilly.

And the smallest gardener, Fern, had the most important job of all. She had to count the stars, so that none of them got lost.

"One, two, three..." Fern counted. "Forty-one, forty-two..." It was a lot of stars.

"Thistle," said Fern, "what if I lose count?"

"Then you start again," said Thistle kindly. "The stars don't mind. They like being counted."

So Fern counted and counted, and every time she lost her place, she smiled and started again.

When the sky began to turn pale at the edges, the gardeners gathered under the biggest moonflower. They were tired and happy and a little bit sleepy.

"Good work, everyone," said Thistle. "Rest now."

And the night gardeners curled up into soft round puffs, and the moonflowers folded their petals around them, and the whole grove fell asleep just as the town woke up.

The end.

For grown-ups: This story was inspired by Puffgrove, a calm iPhone game about tending a moonlit grove of creatures. · Free story from Honest Little Apps · honestlittleapps.github.io/bedtime-stories